

World in Brief: Zelensky sacks top general; Burnham promises first tax cuts



Photograph: Bloomberg via Getty Images

Volodymyr Zelensky sacked Oleksandr Syrsky, **Ukraine's** top general, after [days of protests](#) calling for his ouster. Mykhailo Drapaty, the commander of Ukraine's joint forces, will replace him. Demonstrators have also been demanding the reinstatement of Mykhailo Fedorov, the popular defence minister whom Mr Zelensky [dismissed](#) in a cabinet reshuffle last week. The modernising Mr Fedorov had clashed with General Syrsky.

Andy Burnham said he would cut taxes on electricity bills on his first full day as Britain's prime minister—a [modest start](#) despite his [bold rhetoric](#). Critics dismissed the £850m (\$1.1bn) policy, which will save the average household £45 a year, as “unfunded”. Mr Burnham insisted that his new Labour government would maintain “fiscal discipline” as it attempts to “take a little pressure” off the costs of living in Britain.

Novo Nordisk sued **Eli Lilly**, its main American rival, for misleading advertisements of its [weight-loss medicine](#). The Danish drugmaker said Lilly made “maliciously and deceptively false” claims that its diabetes and obesity medicine was more effective than Novo Nordisk's by “intentionally” selecting outdated clinical studies. Lilly has not responded to the claims.

Ozgur Ozel, the deposed leader of **Turkey's** main opposition group, said he would form a new party to challenge President Recep Tayyip Erdogan. Mr Ozel was [removed as leader](#) of the Republican People's Party by a court in May, in what was seen as a political crackdown. Recent polling suggests his new party, which is yet to be named, is already ahead of Mr Erdogan's.

Marco Rubio, America's secretary of state, called on the international community to cut off **Nicaragua**, after Daniel Ortega, its co-president, said the country [would "never" hold elections again](#). During almost two decades of rule, Mr Ortega has regularly suppressed opposition. In 2021 he declared himself the winner of a sham election. Mr Rubio said Nicaragua "cannot expect to maintain business as usual".

Some 180 people were injured in clashes with police in **India's** capital, Delhi. The march was called by the [Cockroach Janta Party](#), a youth-led movement, to demand the [resignation](#) of the country's education minister following several exam-related scandals. The protest movement said it would continue its demonstrations but ruled out another march on parliament to protect protesters against alleged "police brutality".

France's parliament passed a bill banning under-15s from using **social media**. The new legislation, which comes into effect in September, will require platforms to immediately impose age-verification checks and shut down the accounts of underage users within four months. Such restrictions are [in the works elsewhere](#): Britain plans to implement its own ban next year—and Australian teens are [already outsmarting a similar law](#).

Figure of the day: 170m. The number of users of Pix. [Find out why](#) Brazil's beloved payments system has drawn Donald Trump's ire.

The war in Ukraine is in flux. But can deep strikes and pioneering drone tactics finally break the stalemate? Join our live panel of experts on [Inside Defence](#) as they analyse the conflict, on Tuesday, July 21st, 6pm BST/1pm EDT.

Lebanon's president heads to Washington



Photograph: Reuters

On Tuesday, for the first time since 2009, a Lebanese president [visited the White House](#). Joseph Aoun's meeting with Donald Trump focused on Hizbullah, the [Iranian-backed Shia militia](#) that has dragged Lebanon into nearly three years of war with Israel. Last month, in a deal brokered by America, Mr Aoun's government agreed to deploy the army in south Lebanon and confiscate Hizbullah's weapons. In return, Israel is meant to withdraw. But the terms of the agreement remain vague.

Mr Aoun's advisers have also drawn up pitches for how American firms might benefit from investing in Lebanon. They will need to make a persuasive case: the country is seven years into a grinding financial crisis, made worse by war. GDP has fallen by around half since 2019; the currency has lost 98% of its value. Mr Aoun's government hopes to conclude a long-delayed agreement with the IMF later this year. It will want Mr Trump's help with that, too.

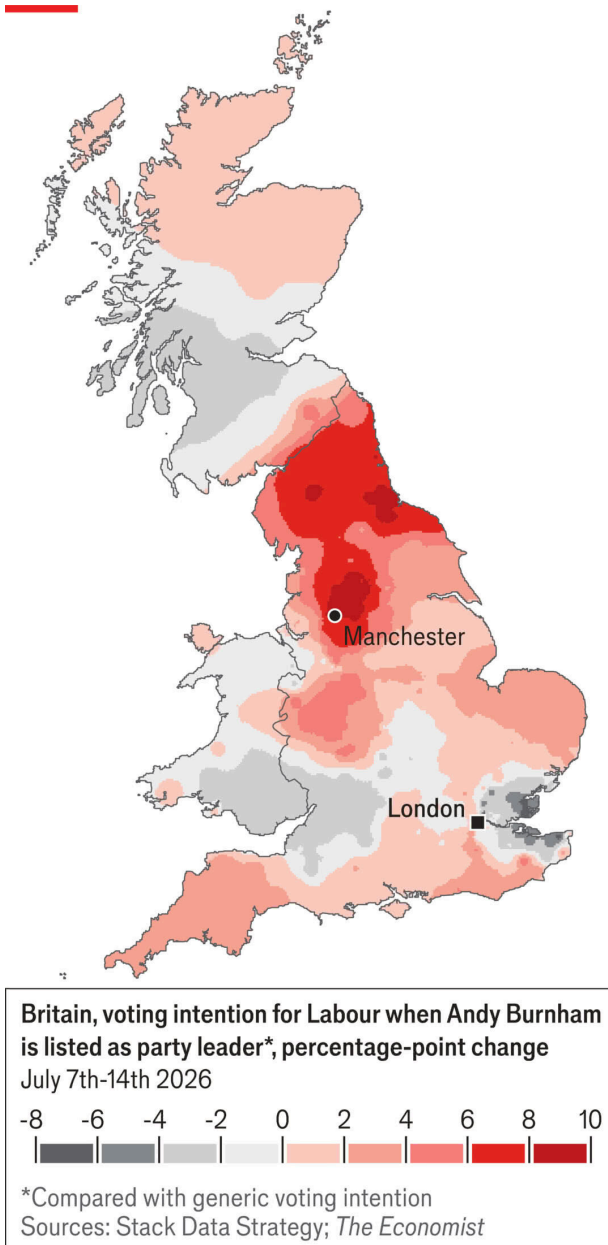
A new era at Number 10



Photograph: Getty Images

On Monday Andy Burnham was [officially appointed as Britain's prime minister](#). Speaking outside 10 Downing Street, he acknowledged that people are “fed up with politics” and promised new economic and political models for the country (particularly in the north of England, where he enjoys strong support). That begins on Tuesday, his first full day in office.

Mr Burnham is already clearing out Sir Keir Starmer's allies from the cabinet. He sacked Rachel Reeves as chancellor, replacing her with John Healey, the former defence secretary [who quit his job last month](#) in protest against deficient military spending. Mr Healey served in the Treasury during the Tony Blair era but was not regarded as a front-runner for the chancellor role. [Saving Britain's economy](#) will be high on Mr Burnham's agenda: this week he will announce new measures intended to help Britons cope with the cost of living, though he insists these will be fully funded with tax rises or spending cuts elsewhere.



No sign of panic in Detroit



Photograph: Shutterstock

Lately, America's "Big Three" carmakers have not had it easy. Costs are through the roof at General Motors, Ford and Stellantis as the impact of the Iran war bites. Their aggressive push into electric vehicles has slowed due to weak demand, forcing [costly cutbacks](#) and write-downs worth billions. General Motors, the largest of the three, reports its second-quarter earnings on Tuesday. Revenue is expected to be flat, year on year, at around \$47bn; it has already reported a 4% fall in vehicle sales.

Despite the headwinds, investors remain upbeat. The Cadillac-maker's share price is up by more than 40% since last July. The financial hit from tariffs will be less severe than initially feared; the firm's projected tariff bill for 2026 has been revised to between \$2.5bn and \$3.5bn, down from \$3bn-4bn. High tariffs on [Chinese EVs](#) have so far protected America's carmakers at home. It also helps that full electrification is still years away. Demand for GM's gas-guzzling trucks and SUVs shows little sign of stalling.

The Myanmar dilemma



Photograph: Getty Images

Foreign ministers from the 11 members of the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN) meet in Manila this week. The bloc is expected to discuss whether to readmit Myanmar's military rulers to its high-level meetings for the first time since they overthrew the government of [Aung San Suu Kyi](#) and seized power in 2021.

Thailand wants [Myanmar's generals](#) back into ASEAN's councils while Singapore refuses to admit them. Others are somewhere in between. Consensus among all 11 members has proved elusive.

Other matters on the table include recent border clashes between Thailand and Cambodia, and tensions between [China](#) and the Philippines in the South China Sea. At the end of the week, foreign ministers from around the world, including Marco Rubio, America's secretary of state, and his Chinese and Russian counterparts, will join a broader set of meetings on Asian security.

A trip through 1980s New York



Photograph: Getty Images

Colson Whitehead, one of only four American novelists to receive two Pulitzer prizes for fiction, has crafted an eclectic body of work. In addition to the requisite coming-of-age novel and two historical ones that brought home the prizes, his oeuvre includes a zombie novel, a satire and a crime-fiction trilogy, set mainly in Harlem, that “Cool Machine”, published on Tuesday, concludes.

The trilogy’s protagonist is Ray Carney, a furniture salesman and fence; the combination of jobs lets him keep one foot in the straight world and one in the crooked. In the three linked novellas that comprise “Cool Machine”, he navigates a changing [New York](#) in the 1980s: assisting a master thief, retrieving a stolen mask and helping the son of his beloved late cousin. The trilogy’s only flaw is Carney’s relative blandness compared with Mr Whitehead’s wry, often laugh-aloud-funny narration. The series is a valentine to New York grit.

Daily quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Tuesday: Which all-female rock group had hits such as “Walk Like An Egyptian” and “Manic Monday”?

Monday: Head & Shoulders is the best selling brand of which type of household product?

All words, in every language, are metaphors.

Marshall McLuhan